

Finding Harriet Jacobs' Underground Railroad Safe House in Philadelphia

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The Arrival

In the Spring of 1842, Harriet Jacobs arrived in Philadelphia and was met at the docks by Reverend Jeremiah Durham. Rev. Durham served as a minister at Mother Bethel AME and also worked as an Underground Railroad agent. Someone had informed him to meet Jacobs, a freedom seeker, at the docks. Recognizing her exhaustion, he invited her to stay with his family.

Upon arriving at the Durham home, Jacobs recalled: "Mrs. Durham met me with a kindly welcome, without asking any questions. I was tired and her friendly manner was a sweet refreshment." Though Jacobs initially intended to continue to New York quickly, the Durham family's kindness persuaded her to remain for five full days in Philadelphia.

During her stay, Jacobs observed daily street life from the Durham home's window, noting: "At daylight, I heard women crying fresh fish, berries radishes and various other things. All this was new to me." Most significantly, it was at the Durham residence where she first met a Vigilance Committee member and began sharing her personal narrative.

The Importance of This Safe House

Philadelphia served as a crucial rest stop for freedom seekers traveling north via the Eastern Underground Railroad. The Durham home provided not only physical shelter but emotional support that enabled Jacobs to eventually document her harrowing journey in her published work. The author emphasizes the need to recognize the countless community members who opened their homes and supported those seeking liberation.

Locating the House: Research Methodology

Verifying Jeremiah Durham's Existence

The researchers consulted the 1838 Census and discovered Jeremiah Durham listed on Barley Street. They confirmed he was the only Jeremiah Durham in Philadelphia between 1838 and 1847, and verified his presence in the 1840 U.S. Census in Cedar Ward.

Confirming His Religious Role

While city directories listed Durham's occupation as "Carter" in the late 1830s and early 1840s, historical records confirmed he preached at Shiloh Baptist Church during the 1840s. According to *The Rise and Progress of Shiloh Baptist*, Durham preached at the church's 11th Street location beginning in 1841, making him known as "Reverend" when Jacobs arrived in 1842, even if his directory listing hadn't yet updated.

Pinpointing the Exact Address

Using the 1860 Hexamer and Locher map, researchers determined that Barley Street is now known as Waverly Street. A genealogy website referenced a Philadelphia deed (GS 45:511), which they obtained from Philadelphia Land Records.

The deed described the property: "That certain tenement and lot or piece of ground situate on the south side of Barley Street... beginning at the distance of 159 ft Westward from the west side of Delaware 10th Street, containing in front breadth of said Barley Street 15 ft and in length a depth southward 62 ft."

The deed revealed that Durham sold the property to Stephen Smith, identified as a lumber merchant and AME minister. This connection to Beneficial Hall further validated the finding. Philadelphia Historic Commission official Jon Farnham confirmed that the house currently at **1016 Waverly Street** existed in 1840 and corresponds to the deed's description.

Experiencing the Space Today

The street remains largely unchanged since Jacobs's time. The current owners have preserved historic elements including original ceiling beams, floors, and stairs. Visitors can imagine Jacobs, Jane Durham, Rev. Durham, and a Vigilance Committee member gathered by the fireplace as she shared her story for the first time—a compassionate reception that likely encouraged her eventual public testimony.

Images

- AI Image - arriving in Philadelphia after a long journey on the Underground Railroad — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_1c5384ba7f274941a2021833a3068496~mv2.png

- Volume 4, Page 16 of the 1838 PAS Census, Courtesy Historical Society of Pennsylvania — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_4ce6380a02dc40cc88df3a03ff4f7ecc~mv2.png
- 1842 McElroy's City Directory, Courtesy Internet Archive — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_bd11791c8fb145be8a09c0c844b654eb~mv2.png
- Excerpt from Deed GS: 45: 511. Courtesy Philadelphia Land Records — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_314aac52ea514349a3428f8fa2c49956~mv2.png
- The house where Harriet Jacobs stayed in Philadelphia- an Underground Railroad safe house. Photo courtesy Apartments.com — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_385c97697b064141b153c10553e30d7a~mv2.png
- The authors walking down Barley Street, just as Harriet Jacobs did, almost 200 years ago — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_33bfb6a66084f1095b17ec48a523d00~mv2.png
- Living Room of 1016 Waverly Street, Courtesy Apartments.Com — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_b56582b8680648b69777da0f9d02a095~mv2.png

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